24-System: August 2026 Playtest

Survival horror about preparation, body commitment, and desperate choices. Playtest focus: clear decisions, meaningful push costs, fast resolution. **TODO** marks missing playtest material.

1. Your Character

Buy Skills

Start with **10 build points (BP)** to spend across the eight skills below.

Every skill starts at **2d12 for 0 BP**. Buy upgrades for either skill die independently; the dice do not need to match or follow the standard ladder.

Individual skill die	Total BP cost (incremental upgrade)	Rank contribution
`d12`	0	0
`d10 + 2`	1	1
`d8 + 4`	4(+3)	2
`d6 + 6`	9(+5)	3
`d4 + 8`	16(+7)	4

The first number is the total cost per die, equal to **that die's rank contribution squared**; parentheses show the additional BP needed to upgrade from the preceding die. Add both dice's costs for the skill's total cost and both flat bonuses for its roll. Upgrades require only the BP cost; there is no supporting-skill requirement.

Skill rank: Each single die-step upgrade increases the skill's rank by **1**. Add the rank contributions of both dice: `2d12` is rank 0, `d10 + d12 + 2` is rank 1, and both `2d10 + 4` and `d8 + d12 + 4` are rank 2. Rank counts upgrade steps, not BP spent.

Costs: `d12 + d10 + 2` costs **1 BP**; `2d10 + 4` costs **2 BP**; `d8 + d12 + 4` costs **4 BP**. `2d4 + 16` costs **32 BP**.

Example starting allocation: Melee rank 3 (`d8 + d10 + 6`, 5 BP), Athletics and Ranged each rank 2 (`2d10 + 4`, 2 BP each), and Lore rank 1 (`d10 + d12 + 2`, 1 BP) spend **10 BP**. All other skills remain rank 0.

Record each skill's rank, purchased dice, and combined bonus. Each skill describes a broad area of action:

Skill	Brief description
Athletics	Strength, speed, endurance, balance, and movement through difficult terrain.
Melee	Close-quarters attacks, defense, positioning, and physical control.
Ranged	Attacks and tactical actions with bows, firearms, and other distant weapons.
Thievery	Stealth, infiltration, locks, traps, sleight of hand, and concealment.
Lore	History, languages, culture, religion, folklore, and general interpretation.

Skill	Brief description
Science	Technical knowledge, investigation, medicine, engineering, and applied analysis.
Social	Persuasion, deception, intimidation, rapport, and reading people.
Magic	Spells, rituals, supernatural effects, and the risks of wielding them.

Choose Traits

Traits define how your character approaches danger, survival, and problem-solving.

Choose **2 traits** from any categories below.

Martial and Survivor Traits

- **Sweep** - Once per round, as an `R(L)FH` action, attack 2 different melee targets at the regular DC instead of the Full Martial Attack DC.
- **Strong Back** - Carry 1 extra Large item without penalty.
- **Weapon Familiarity** - Choose one weapon type; gain one advantage step when using it.
- **Shield-Bearer** - You may shove or bash with a shield and still use `R` to Block once this round.
- **Tireless Runner** - Sprint and jog distance before stamina loss is doubled.
- **Elite Athlete** - Choose running, climbing, or swimming; increase distance by 50%.
- **Pack Fighter** - Gain one advantage step when adjacent to an ally attacking the same target.
- **Tough** - First time you are wounded in a combat, reduce that wound by 1.
- **Quick Draw** - Ready a weapon and attack in the same action.
- **Guarded Swing** - Once per round, if you used `L` for an attack on your turn, you may still Parry with `L`.
- **Acrobatic Finesse** - If you used `Sprint` or `Leap` this turn, you may still Dodge as a reaction..

Social and Leadership Traits

- **Commander** - Use your `H` action and make a Social check at DC `13 + the target's current Fear`. On a success, reduce the target character's Fear by 1 level; on a Partial Critical success, reduce it by 2 levels instead.
- **Psychologist** - Once per session, make a Science check at DC `18` to address one specific Bane affecting another character. Track successes across sessions for that character and Bane. After you accumulate 3 successes, that character can ignore that Bane at will.
- **Silver Tongue** - Once per scene, reroll a failed Social check.
- **Inspiring Presence** - Allies within earshot gain one advantage vs fear or fatigue checks.
- **Streetwise** - Gain minor hints or rumors when asking NPCs.
- **Menacing** - On a successful Intimidate, target hesitates (losses H action) for one round before acting aggressively.

Survivalist and Explorer Traits

- **Medic** - Use 1 medical supply to temporarily negate 1 wound penalty for a day. The character remains

wounded but suffers no penalty for using that limb.

- **Keen Senses** - Guide always provides one extra environmental clue when you search.
- **Forager** - Roll a DC 16 lore check, if successful you negate 1 hunger and sleep penalty for the day.
- **Toughened** - Reduce stamina damage from environmental hazards by 1.
- **Pathfinder** - Wilderness travel time is reduced by one tier.
- **Trapwise** - You always notice at least one clue that a nearby trap exists.

Mystic and Lore Traits

- **Arcane Sensitivity** - You sense nearby magic, even faint traces.
- **Ritual Memory** - Perform one simple ritual per day without materials.
- **Scholar of the Old World** - Gain one advantage step on Lore checks about pre-disaster knowledge.
- **Dream-Touched** - Guide provides vague prophetic fragments during sleep.
- **Talisman-Bearer** - Once per session, negate a Minor Complication.

Rogue and Trickster Traits

- **Quick Fingers** - Automatic success on simple locks or simple traps under low pressure.
- **Shadowstep** - Gain one advantage step on Thievery in low light.
- **Evasive** - First hit per combat deals one fewer wound.
- **Deceptive Feint** - On a miss, target suffers `+2 DC` on its next attack against you this round.
- **Light Foot** - Ignore minor encumbrance penalties while sneaking or climbing.
- **Skulker** - Ignore low-light penalties and reduce no-light penalties by one step for Thievery actions.

Dark and Gritty Survival Traits

- **Foolhardy** - You rarely appreciate danger until it is already happening. Reduce incoming Fear by 1.
- **Cowardly** - Your imagination races ahead of you. Increase Fear gained by 1.
- **Brave** - Use your `H` action to treat your Fear as 2 levels lower for determining movement restrictions for the remainder of your turn.
- **Scarred Survivor** - After a Major Complication, gain one advantage on your next action.
- **Double Down** - Once per scene, after a pushed roll fails, resolve all its consequences, then push once more if a plausible experimental approach remains. Agree on a new minor cost and reroll both dice at the same DC using Push Your Luck v2. No Leverage applies to either push; this cannot undo consequences or make an impossible attempt possible.
- **Desperate Strength** - When at negative stamina, your first successful attack in a scene gains +1 wound.
- **Grim Reputation** - Gain one advantage step on Intimidate; suffer `+2 DC` on Persuade against neutral or friendly targets.
- **Bloodied but Unbowed** - First wound in combat causes you to gain 1 stamina.

- **Diehard** - Roll `1d12` instead of `1d6` to determine your death threshold from bleeding after unconsciousness: **-5 - 1d12 stamina**.

Equipment

Starting gear (included, $2.80 value): Light pack, filled waterskin, 3 days' trail food, bedroll, fire kit, lantern, oil flask, 2 field dressings, knife, pre-marked quarter ward.
Spending money: Guide chooses **$2.20** (lean) or **$5** (better equipped) per character, in addition to this gear; spend freely, keep the remainder. Prices are survivor silver, `$1 = 100c`.

Supplies and Tools

Item	Size	Price
Filled / empty waterskin	Medium / Small	10c / 5c
Trail food, 1 day / preserved food, 1 week	Small / Medium	10c / 50c
Hot meal	Small	2–5c
Salt pouch, coffee/tea ration, dry socks (each)	Small	5c
Bedroll, heavy blanket (each)	Large	25c
Oilskin tarp	Large	50c
Tent, one-person / group	Large	$1 / $3
Winter coat	Worn	$1
Gloves/scarf/hat set	Small	25c
Fire kit / matchbox	Small / Tiny	25c / 5c
Lantern / oil flask	Medium / Small	50c / 10c
Bandage roll / field dressing	Small	5c / 10c
Splint kit	Medium	10c
Antiseptic vial, painkiller dose (each)	Tiny	25c
Surgical kit / stretcher cloth	Medium	$2 / 25c
Knife	Small	25c
Hatchet, hand saw, crowbar (each)	Medium	50c
Hammer, rope (50 ft) (each)	Medium	25c
Sewing/repair kit	Small	25c
Lockpicks, compass (each)	Tiny	$1
Shovel	Large	50c
Local map	Small	25c–$2

Melee Weapons

Item	Size	Base damage	Properties	Price
Dagger	Small	1	Precision, Grappling	25c
Shield	Large	1	Knockback, Block	50c
Club	Large	1	Penetrating	5c

Item	Size	Base damage	Properties	Price
Staff (two-handed)	Large	2	Reach, Brace	5c
Morning star (2H)	Large	2	Penetrating	$25+
Machete, axe (each)	Medium	1	Chopping	$1
Short sword	Medium	1	Parry	$1
Spear	Large	2	Precision, Reach, Brace	50c

Availability: A staff is an inexpensive wooden weapon at **5c**. The morning star is a two-handed armor-breaking weapon priced at **$25+**: in this setting's 1920s Massachusetts, obtaining a functional antique or arranging a special commission is costly, and ordinary suppliers do not stock it.

Ranged Weapons

Item	Size	Base damage	Properties	Ammo capacity	Price
Short bow	Large	1	Precision	—	$1
Long bow	Large	1	Precision, Long Range	—	$1
Light crossbow	Medium	1	Penetrating, Reloading	1	$2
Pistol	Small	2	Penetrating, Reloading	5	$5+
Rifle	Large	3	Penetrating, Long Range, Reloading	5	$10+
Shotgun	Large	2	Knockback, Reloading	5	$5+
10 arrows/bolts	Medium	—	—	—	25c
6 firearm rounds	Tiny	—	—	—	50c
Silvered bullet	Tiny	—	—	—	25c+
Molotov bottle	Small	Special	Lit (when lit)	—	25c

Base damage: Listed values are wounds on a normal successful hit, before mitigation. One-handed weapons normally deal 1 wound; two-handed weapons deal 2. Use the hands required for the attack to determine the baseline. Listed weapon values override these baselines: bows deal 1 wound, pistols deal 2 wounds, and rifles deal 3. Shotguns are two-handed and deal 2 base wounds. Critical damage adds to the listed base damage; see Attacks below. Molotovs use the Burning Fuel rules in damage-types.md.

Weapon properties: A weapon has at most one primary property (Precision, Chopping, Penetrating, or Knockback) and may also have qualities (Grappling, Long Range, Reloading, Reach, Parry, Block, Brace, or Lit). Critical effects require a successful hit. Knockback applies on any successful hit. See weapons.md for details.

- **Precision:** On a Partial Critical, causes bleed 1, On a legendary, bleed 2.
- **Chopping:** On a Partial Critical, armor loses 2 Integrity instead of

the normal 1; on a Legendary, it loses 4.

- **Penetrating:** On a Partial Critical, armor converts 1 fewer wound to stamina; on a Legendary, it converts 2 fewer, to a minimum conversion of 0.
- **Knockback:** On a successful hit against a creature engaged in Melee, push it out of that engagement to Separated. Resolve damage and armor conversion normally; Knockback applies even if armor converts all wounds to stamina.
- **Grappling:** Gain +1 Leverage on ordinary attack checks when attacking with this weapon while grappling with the target.
- **Long Range:** Can attack a visible, identifiable target beyond the immediate encounter, such as someone on a distant rooftop or across a valley. Rifles and long bows have this quality; other ranged weapons attack within the immediate encounter. Normal attack, defense, and cover rules apply.
- **Reloading:** Spend an `LR` action (both hands) to refill the weapon up to its ammo capacity using suitable, accessible ammunition. Each shot consumes 1 round or bolt, hit or miss; an empty weapon cannot fire. Crossbows hold 1 bolt and reload after every shot; firearms hold 5 rounds.
- **Reach:** Ward advances from Separated to Melee, Melee to Grappling, and Move-By attempts; most benefits are lost while grappling.
- **Parry:** You may Parry with `L` after attacking with `L` in the same round.
- **Block:** Use the hand holding the shield (`L` or `R`) to Block: first wound free, remaining wounds convert to 1 stamina loss each. The hand must be uncommitted unless a trait overrides this; blocking risks shield Integrity.
- **Brace:** Improve warding when the weapon is set against a charge or advance.
- **Lit:** Active flame may cause Fear 1, trigger Light Exposure, or ignite Flammable material; it adds no wound damage by default. Molotovs use the Burning Fuel rules in damage-types.md.

Wards

Item	Size	Price
Silver dime, quarter, half dollar, dollar	Tiny	10c, 25c, 50c, $1
Pre-marked wards, same denominations	Tiny	15c, 35c, 75c, $1.50
Silver filings, pinch / silver wire, short	Tiny / Small	5c / 50c+

24-hour Latch-Star protection, dime = weak, quarter = practical, half = serious, dollar = strongest common. Pre-marked prices include rune work.

Armor — Whole Sets

Use one worn armor tier for every hit location. Each converted wound costs **1 stamina**; excess wounds apply normally. Worn armor uses no pack space. Integrity below uses the core whole-set values.

Armor	Tier	Wounds converted/hit	Integrity	Movement	Carried size	Price
Reinforced Workwear	Light	1	2	—	Medium	$1
Early Bulletproof Vest	Medium	2	3	-1 MR	Medium	$2
WWI Surplus Flak Jacket	Medium	2	3	-1 MR	Medium	$3
Civil Security Kit	Medium	2	3	-1 MR	Medium	$4
Industrial Plate Vest	Heavy	3	5	-2 MR	Large	$3
Trench Assault Harness	Heavy	3	5	-2 MR	Large	$5
Makeshift Shield	Block	First wound free, rest stamina	3	—	Large	50c

The Shield in the melee table uses the defensive stats of the Makeshift Shield listed here.

Armor quality: Poor = -1 Integrity, half price; Standard = listed values; Superior = +2 Integrity, double price. Repair requires suitable tools, time, materials, relevant check. Light armor is common, heavy armor rare/loud, bulletproof gear extremely rare. Shield occupies one hand, uses Block/Cover, protects mainly from the front. **MR = movement rate.**

Packs and Containers

Item	Size	Price
Light / medium / heavy pack	Worn	50c / $1 / $2
Small sack	Tiny empty, Small filled	2c
Medium sack	Small empty, Medium filled	5c
Large sack	Medium empty, Large filled	10c
Belt/bandolier	Worn	10c
Holster/sheath	Tiny/Small	5c
Rigid case, Small / Medium / Large	As named	10c / 25c / 50c
Seal / Careful Storage quality	Container upgrade	+10c / +25c

Sizes: 2 Medium = 1 Large, 10 Small = 1 Medium, 100 Tiny = 1 Small. Assign gear to actual pockets/attachments; the starting light pack cannot contain the entire loadout. Carry some gear in hand, share it, or buy more carrying capacity.

Pack	Movement	Hit die	Numbered slots (1 = pack itself)
Light	—	d6	2 Large attachment, 3 Medium pocket, 4–6 Small pockets
Medium	-1 MR	d8	2 Large attachment, 3–4 Medium pockets, 5–8 Small pockets

Pack	Movement	Hit die	Numbered slots (1 = pack itself)
Heavy	-2 MR	d12	2–3 Large attachments, 4–6 Medium pockets, 7–12 Small pockets

Access: Exposed attachments = immediate with free hand, pack pocket/sack = Hand action, nested storage = access each layer, doff pack = Hand action.

Belts/bandoliers: 4 Small or 100 Tiny attachments, no pack space used; torso gear hit rolls `d4` or `d100` respectively, item affected first, empty slot = holder damaged only.

Sacks: Use matching hand/pocket/attachment capacity, add no capacity themselves. Hand-carried sack occupies that hand. Nested sack keeps spilled gear together but does not protect fragile contents.

Rigid cases: Store items at least one size smaller, container takes damage first, contents affected if breached or directly reached. Careful Storage keeps fragile contents together/protected when the outer pocket spills; only one protective layer applies.

Seal: Protects from ordinary water, dust, contamination, leakage until opened/breached/overwhelmed. Waterskin = sealed sack; filled skin supports one survivor's rest without nearby water, puncture leaks.

Pack damage: Roll hit die, damage numbered slot; pocket/attachment tears and spills contents, empty slot loses only its holder, slot 1 damages pack itself. Fragile spills may break, exposed flammable contents ignite in fire.

Market adjustments: Non-armor damaged gear = half price, excellent condition = ×1.5; scarcity/restriction = ×2, urgent life-saving need = ×2 or more. Armor uses its own quality prices above.

TODO — Character sheet: Sheet with the stamina and wound tracks below, ready-to-play characters.

2. Making a Check

Core Resolution Ladder

The standard step-down progression from core.md, extended through d4, alternates upgrades between the two dice. Other combinations are allowed at the same rank. Costs below are the combined squared costs of the two dice.

Rank	Standard roll	Average Score	Total BP cost
0	`2d12`	13	0
1	`d10 + d12 + 2`	14	1
2	`2d10 + 4`	15	2
3	`d8 + d10 + 6`	16	5
4	`2d8 + 8`	17	8
5	`d6 + d8 + 10`	18	13
6	`2d6 + 12`	19	18
7	`d4 + d6 + 14`	20	25
8	`2d4 + 16`	21	32

Every combination at rank R has an average of **13 + R**. For example, rank 2 can be `2d10 + 4` (2 BP) or `d8 + d12 + 4` (4 BP); both average 15. Roll the dice actually purchased, not automatically the standard combination at that rank.

Dice Resolution

1. Choose the skill and read its purchased dice and bonuses.
2. Roll those two dice and add their combined flat bonus once.
3. **Leverage X** grants up to X optional single-die rerolls on an ordinary check. After seeing the dice, choose either die to reroll and keep its new result, even if worse. You may reroll the same die again or stop. Add flat bonuses only once. Finish Leverage decisions before deciding to push; no Leverage applies to pushed rolls. One advantage step grants one such reroll on an ordinary skill check. Fear grants Leverage equal to its current value on initiative rolls, using the same reroll procedure.
4. Compare the result to the Difficulty (DC). Meeting or beating the DC succeeds.

On an ordinary check, if either final die shows its maximum value, the roll is a **Partial Critical** and gains a small additional benefit. A final result of 24 is a **Legendary Success** and gains a major additional benefit. Discarded results do not trigger critical effects. Pushed checks use the exceptions below.

If the result is below the DC, the result is considered no effect, no progress, or otherwise a failure. The is no other consequence, unless...

Push Your Luck

Your first roll represents your best reasonable effort, including familiar methods and the tricks you know within the available time and resources. After failure, **pushing**

means trying an experimental technique beyond your reliable experience. Describe the dangerous change; repeating the same method or saying "I try harder" is not enough.

A novice has many untried approaches an expert would consider routine. An expert's first roll already accounts for those options; what remains reaches further into dangerous territory. Smaller expert dice make success more reliable but pushed complications more frequent: **overreach, not lost competence**. Scheduled multi-round progress checks remain ordinary checks; pushing is optional.

Procedure: After a failed check and all ordinary-check Leverage decisions, agree with the Guide on the experimental approach, an immediate minor cost, and the consequences at risk. **Push once:** reroll both skill dice at the **same DC**, keeping the new result and usual flat bonuses. **No Leverage rerolls apply**, even if some were unused; accept both pushed dice. This also applies to Double Down.

No DC reductions: Neither pushing nor Double Down lowers the DC. Leverage changes die results, not the DC.

Final pushed result	Outcome
Meets DC, no natural 1s	Success plus the agreed minor cost.
Below DC, no natural 1s	**Critical Failure:** fail and escalate the agreed cost to a Major Complication.
Exactly one natural 1	Add a minor complication to either result above; success becomes a**Partial Critical Failure** that still achieves the action.
Double 1s	**Legendary Failure:** the action fails regardless of total, with an exceptional disaster tied to the approach. Replaces lesser failure effects; do not charge the same cost twice.

Success benefits remain: On a successful push, a maximum face grants a **Partial Critical Success** benefit, and a total of 24 grants the **Legendary Success** benefit. Benefits and complications can occur together; neither cancels the other or the agreed cost. A maximum does not rescue a total below the DC, and double 1s override the total.

Costs: Position, Resource, Exposure, Strain, or Objective. Minor = a setback preserving options (noise, torn pocket, lose 1 stamina); major = a serious immediate problem (pinned, critical gear lost, alarm, lose 4 stamina). Legendary consequences must fit the established stakes, not automatically cause death. Direct harm to another PC requires a risk clear before rolling, significant benefit, and table agreement. **Double Down** permits one further push as described in its trait.

Example: An expert fails a DC 20 repair and pushes by bypassing a safeguard, risking their tools. Their `2d4 + 16` shows `1, 4`: total 21. The repair works; the maximum restores power faster than expected, while the `1` makes the mechanism grind noisily. The agreed tool-damage cost also applies. No Leverage can change the pushed dice. A `1, 2` instead fails with

a Major Complication plus an additional minor complication; `1, 1` is Legendary Failure.

See Push Your Luck v2 for the full rule and design explanation.

Setting the DC

Use two different methods:

- **Contested roll:** The DC is the opposing character's average result for the relevant skill (**13 + skill rank**). The acting character must meet or beat that average.
- **Unopposed roll:** Use either a one-round action or a multi-round action, as described below.

One-Round Actions

Use one roll when the action resolves in a single round. Set the DC from the table below, then apply any Pressure or other situational modifiers.

Difficulty	DC	Example
Easy	8	A small pit or a straightforward action under pressure.
Medium	10	A routine challenge with meaningful uncertainty.
Hard	12	A medium pit or a demanding action.
Very Hard	14	A severe challenge requiring strong skill or good conditions.
Confounding	16	An extreme action that a specialist may still fail.
Scary	18	A challenge with very little room for error.
Legendary	20	An action that borders on impossible.

Multi-Round Actions

Use a multi-round action when success requires time, concentration, or repeated progress.

- The **DC** measures how difficult it is to make progress in a single round.
- The **required successes** measure the total size and duration of the task.

Each round, the player makes one check against the progress DC. A success marks one progress success. An ordinary failure only consumes that round. The player may Push Their Luck as normal, accepting the usual complication risk.

Example: Picking a Lock

Exploration is moving in ten-minute moments. The Guide decides that picking this lock is a Short task requiring 2 successes. Making progress on the lock is DC 14.

TODO — Modifiers and preparation: Define Pressure mechanics, Leverage sources and stacking, maintenance kits/high-quality gear, and any separate push-protection effects.

3. Taking Action

The RHLF ("Ralph") Action System

The 24-System uses a **body-anchored action economy** called the **RHLF Action System**, informally known as the **"Ralph" system**. Rather than abstract action points, characters commit **parts of their body** to perform actions.

RHLF stands for:

- **L** – Primary Hand (the hand holding the weapon)
- **R** – Secondary Hand (optional or supporting)
- **H** – Head (awareness, targeting, balance, intent)
- **F** – Feet (stance, movement, positioning)

These anchors determine **what actions are possible**, **what bonuses apply**, and **what happens when a character is injured or exhausted**.

Action Commitment

Every action specifies which body anchors it requires.

Examples:

- `L` – One-handed action
- `LH` – One-handed action with focus or targeting
- `(R)LHF` – A fully committed martial action using:
  - Primary hand
  - Optional secondary hand (two-handed weapon)
  - Head (awareness, timing)
  - Feet (stance and balance)

Parentheses indicate optional commitment, usually for two-handed weapons or heavier techniques.

Fear and Initiative

Abbreviated from Fear and Initiative. Track **Fear from 0 to 6**: it speeds reactions but restricts actions.

Combat start:

1. Every character and monster rolls **`2d12` with Leverage equal to their current Fear**. Finish the optional single-die rerolls, keeping each new result even if worse. Record the two final dice and their total, including flat initiative modifiers once.
2. Resolve **enemy initiative critical moves first**, recording the Fear they cause.
3. Resolve **player initiative critical moves next**, making any required Athletics checks and recording Fear reductions.
4. **Set new Fear levels** by applying the recorded gains and reductions, with traits and Banes. Keep tracked Fear at a minimum of 0 and resolve any mental break at Fear 6.
5. Use the **recorded initiative scores**, highest to lowest, to decide who goes first. **Players win ties against monsters**; tied players decide their order among themselves, and the Guide orders tied monsters.

Initiative modifiers: Surprised `-2`, Low Light `-1`, Darkness `-2`, Distracted `-1`, Severely Distracted `-2`. Applicable flat modifiers stack and apply once; Fear supplies Leverage.

Initiative criticals: A final d12 showing **12** grants a Partial Critical; a final initiative total of **24** grants a

Legendary. Discarded dice do not count. Resolve these during combat setup, enemies before players. Use the Legendary outcome instead of the Partial Critical outcome.

Combatant	Partial Critical	Legendary
Monster	Move to **Melee** with a chosen character, if possible; record **+2 Fear** for that character.	Move to **Grappling** with a chosen character, if possible; record **+4 Fear** for that character.
Player character	Move up to **MR**, making any required **Athletics checks**; record **-2 Fear**.	Move up to **twice MR**, making any required **Athletics checks**; record **-4 Fear**.

This bonus movement does not spend the normal F action. Normal movement rules for terrain, Guard, engagement, injury, and current Fear restrictions apply. A monster already at the indicated range or closer does not move away; record its Fear effect even if movement is blocked or unnecessary. After both groups finish moving, apply each character's net Fear change, applying Fear traits to incoming Fear and retaining applicable Bane modifiers.

Actions readied before combat can trigger during setup movement. Resolve them at their declared Interrupt or Follow-up timing, then continue setup.

Use Fear at the beginning of the roll to determine Leverage. Updated Fear affects subsequent actions; the recorded initiative scores stay the same. Once turns begin, follow the order in a cycle. Later Fear changes update restrictions while the current order continues.

Act before being attacked: At the start of your first turn in combat, reduce Fear by **1** if no attack has been attempted against you since combat began, even an attack that missed. This benefit applies once per combat.

Fear restrictions: Use the current row; Pressure values are totals, not cumulative. Concentration Pressure applies to Lore, Science, Social, and Magic; hostile-action Pressure applies to Melee and Ranged actions against sources of Fear.

Fear	State	Concentration Pressure	Hostile-action Pressure	Restriction
0	Steady	0	0	None.
1	Unease	0	0	None.
2	Tension	1	0	Half-speed movement toward the controlling source.
3	Strain	1	1	Cannot move toward the controlling source.
4	Panic	2	2	Cannot approach; move at least one step away on your turn.
5	Overwhelm	3	3	Cannot approach; use all available movement to move away.

Fear	State	Concentration Pressure	Hostile-action Pressure	Restriction
6	Mental Break	—	—	Immediately reset Fear to 0 and gain a permanent Bane.

Controlling source: Only the source with the highest Fear rating determines movement direction; ties use the most recently encountered source. A newer, weaker source adds Fear without changing that direction. Total current Fear determines restriction severity; hostile-action Pressure still applies against all sources of Fear.

Recovery: In the round immediately after gaining Fear, spend a full RLHF action to reduce Fear by **1**, at most **once per scene**. The opportunity expires after that round; gaining Fear again opens another opportunity but does not reset the once-per-scene limit. Ending a scene does not automatically remove Fear. A **full rest resets Fear to 0**. Recovery changes restrictions immediately but does not reroll initiative. Fear traits above apply normally.

Initiative critical benefits and acting before being attacked reduce Fear separately, without using the recovery action or its once-per-scene allowance.

Madness and Banes: At Fear 6, immediately reset Fear to 0 and gain a permanent Bane tied to the source. During combat setup, resolve the break when setting new Fear levels, before using the recorded scores to determine turn order. Later breaks resolve when the threshold is reached while the current order continues. **Madness and Banes are cumulative:** each break adds a Bane, including another instance of the same Bane, and all applicable effects stack. Each Fear-increasing Bane adds **+1 Fear** while its trigger is present. Two breaks tied to small dogs give **Fear of Small Dogs 2**, adding **+2 Fear** while small dogs are present. Different triggered Fear Banes also add together. Record triggers, effects, and counts. These modifiers affect initiative and restrictions without adding another point each round. Fear reductions and resets lower tracked Fear to a minimum of 0; Banes survive rest and recovery, and their triggered modifiers still apply after a reset.

Delay: On your turn, spend one available RHLF anchor to move to a later position in the circular order, then act there with your remaining anchors and current Fear restrictions. Resolve start-of-turn effects only at your original position.

TODO — Turn procedure: Anchor reset timing, movement allowance.

Defence

One defence per incoming attack, required limb must be uncommitted this round unless a trait/weapon rule overrides. Normal movement preserves Dodge; Sprint/Leap prevents it until your next turn unless a trait overrides. Attack must meet or beat defence DC; cover/concealment modifiers apply afterward.

No Active Defence: Attack DC 13, normal damage on hit.

Dodge (F): Attack DC = average Athletics, avoids all damage on a

miss, always costs stamina; on hit, stamina spent + normal damage.

Parry (L): Weapon required, attack DC = average Melee, no stamina cost. On hit, Guide reduces/redirects damage: -1 wound, weapon/armor integrity loss, or lost balance/position. Partial Critical/Legendary may damage weapon or partially defeat parry. Parrying after attacking requires Parry quality or a trait exception.

Block (L or R): Attack DC 13, intercept hit. Shield = first wound free, remaining wounds convert to stamina loss; other objects = all wounds convert to stamina loss. Blocking items risk integrity loss. Bare arm = wounds to arm up to disabled mark, excess to intended target, no free mitigation.

Cover/Concealment: Stack with defence. Concealment = +1 DC ranged, melee only when awareness/movement meaningfully hindered, no damage absorption. Ranged cover = passive +1 DC, active (F) +2 DC, active benefit lost if moved out of position. Melee cover = interposed object (L or R) uses Block, structural cover (F) +1 DC without absorption. Total cover preventing access = no attack.

Default Guard (H): Automatic when aware, unengaged, H free; contest one approach. Committing H elsewhere ends Guard.

Attacks

Weapon use while grappling: Only one-handed weapons may be used to attack while the wielder is in Grappling.

Wild Swing (L(R)): Weapon attack at +2 DC

Focused Attack (LH): Improved accuracy/control, careful strikes or called shots.

Full Martial Attack (L(R)HF): Fully committed, typically one advantage step or bonus damage, no Guard against additional approaches.

Covering Fire (LH, ammo): On success, defender chooses lose Guard until their next turn or suffer the attack; Partial Critical = both. Breaks shooter's Guard.

Ranged attacks in close combat: Firing from or into a Melee or Grappling engagement adds **+2 DC**. Apply this penalty once per attack, even if both shooter and target are engaged; other difficulty modifiers, including cover, stack normally. A shooter in Grappling may fire only a one-handed weapon.

Attack damage and criticals: A successful weapon attack deals its **listed base damage** from Equipment. On a **Partial Critical**, add **1 wound** and apply the weapon's Partial Critical property effect. On a **Legendary Success**, first apply those Partial Critical bonuses, then **double all numerical values of the attack's effects**, including wounds, armor Integrity loss, additional stamina loss, and armor conversion penalties. Double these effects before resolving normal damage mitigation. One-handed baseline damage and bow damage are **1/2/4 wounds**; two-handed baseline damage and pistol damage are **2/3/6 wounds**; rifle damage is **3/4/8 wounds**, for normal/Partial Critical/Legendary hits. Check each

die for a Partial Critical against its own maximum, before flat bonuses. The attack must still meet or beat its DC; critical results do not turn a miss into a hit. Apply all wounds to the resolved hit location (or declared called-shot location), subject to normal damage mitigation. Critical damage does not add separate hits or allow retargeting between wounds.

Example: A two-handed axe deals **2 wounds** on a normal hit. A Partial Critical deals **3 wounds** and causes **2 armor Integrity loss** from Chopping. A Legendary doubles those values to **6 wounds** and **4 armor Integrity loss**.

Hit locations: Default hit = Core, Partial Critical hit = attacker's choice of arm/legs, Legendary hit (24+) = Head. Called shots declared before rolling: arm/legs unchanged DC, Head `+3 DC`. Core Partial Critical may hit belt/bandolier gear instead (`1d4` Small slots, `1d100` Tiny slots). Blind attacks/grapples typically `+4 DC`.

Combat Awareness (H, Default): as head action, you remain fully aware of all known combatants. Without combat awareness you have difficulty attacking with melee and ranged weapons (DV +2) and defense (creatures attacking you have +1 advantage.)

Random Hit Location

Use random hit location when an effect scatters, splashes, detonates, burns unpredictably, or otherwise does not target a single deliberate body region. See combat.md.

Roll `1d12`:

Roll	Location
1	Head
2-5	Core
6-7	Right Arm
8-9	Left Arm
10-11	Legs
12	Pack / Gear

Pack / Gear is not a body wound track. It means carried or worn equipment is hit, damaged, ignited, contaminated, or otherwise affected as appropriate to the source.

For spreading effects, roll once for the first location, then keep rolling for additional affected locations until a roll repeats. Apply the effect to each unique location rolled before the repeat.

Position and Readiness

Advance (`F`): Move one range closer (Separated, Melee, Grappling), typically Athletics against Guard.
Move (`F`): Reposition/retreat/change facing, retreat safe unless surrounded/restrained, preserves Guard while `H` remains free.

Interrupts and Follow-ups

Triggered Action: You may ready an action **before combat**, while

actively waiting for a specified condition, or **on your turn during combat**. Declare the exact trigger, response, timing, required anchors, and ammunition/stamina costs. Commit at least `H` plus all anchors the action normally requires; those anchors are unavailable for defense while readied, and others can see you are waiting.

- **Interrupt:** Resolve when the trigger starts, before the triggering action fully resolves.
- **Follow-up:** Resolve when the trigger finishes, after the triggering action resolves.

Follow trigger wording exactly: "If something enters, I shoot it" includes any entrant; a narrower declaration triggers only on its specified condition. Once triggered, the response fires at its declared timing even if it is now undesirable.

Before combat, the declaration lasts while you maintain your attention and preparation. It carries through combat setup until the start of your first turn. During combat, it expires at the start of your next turn if untriggered; you may ready it again then. Resolve any triggered response at its declared timing, including when the trigger starts combat or occurs during setup movement. Apply normal action costs, checks, and current Fear restrictions, using the committed anchors, then continue setup or the existing turn order.

Abort: You may cancel before the trigger occurs. To abort a readied attack after it triggers, roll **`2d12`** against the normal attack DC. On a hit, choose **normal damage** or **no damage and a Minor Complication** instead; on a miss, the attack misses. Resolve the usual ammunition and stamina costs. See Triggered Action for the broader combat rule.

4. Surviving the Consequences

Wounds

A basic human has separate wound tracks for the **Head**, **Left Arm**, **Right Arm**, **Legs**, and **Torso (Core)**. Each track starts unwounded; each wound advances the affected location one step.

Location	Wound track
Head	injury(+1 DC) -> injury (+2 DC) -> Disabled -> Unconscious
Left Arm	injury(+1 DC) -> injury (+2 DC) -> Disabled
Right Arm	injury(+1 DC) -> injury (+2 DC) -> Disabled
Legs	injury(+1 DC) -> injury (+2 DC) -> Disabled
Torso (Core)	Injury (+1 DC) -> Injury (+2 DC) -> Injury (+3 DC) -> Injury (+4 DC) -> Injury (+5 DC) -> Unconscious

Injury penalties increase the DC of actions involving the injured location. Use the current step's DC penalty and Bleeding rating; these replace earlier values on that location's track rather than adding to them. Disabled or Crippled arms and legs cannot be used. Crippled limbs remain attached and can recover through medical care.

Final wound steps: Reaching the fourth Head wound or sixth Core wound causes **Unconsciousness**; the character cannot act or defend. Reaching the final step of any wound track causes **Bleeding 3**. A track cannot advance beyond its final step: excess wounds cause that step's consequences rather than automatic death or dismemberment. Bleeding can still kill an unconscious character under the rules below.

Stamina and Bleeding

A human typically starts with **3 stamina**, with a normal maximum of **3**. At **-5 stamina**, the character falls unconscious.

Bleeding 1 causes the loss of **1 stamina per round**; **Bleeding 2** causes the loss of **2 stamina per round**; **Bleeding 3** causes the loss of **3 stamina per round**. Bleeding continues while a character is unconscious.

Stop Bleeding: Make a **Science check at DC 7 + 2 × the Bleeding value**: Bleed 1 is **DC 9**, Bleed 2 is **DC 11**, Bleed 3 is **DC 13**, and so on. Success removes the Bleeding condition entirely; on failure, bleeding continues normally. This stops further bleeding loss but does not heal wounds or restore lost stamina. Use the Treat Wound action (`L(R)H`) in skills.md.

If bleeding continues after unconsciousness, roll `1d6` once to determine the character's death threshold: **-5 - 1d6 stamina**. The character dies when bleeding reduces their stamina to or below that threshold. For example, a roll of 4 means death at **-9 stamina**.

Characters with **Diehard** roll `1d12` instead, giving a death threshold of **-5 - 1d12 stamina**.

Guide suggestion: Roll the death die in secret and keep the result and

death threshold hidden, including for characters with Diehard. Players should not know exactly how many rounds a bleeding character has left to live.

Healing and Medical Care

A night of rest with successful medical care reduces **each injured wound track by one level**, to a minimum of unwounded.

- One caregiver may treat **multiple patients in a night**. Choose the patients, spend **1 medical supply per patient**, and make one **Science check** for the night's care.
- **Treatment DC = 12 + total wound levels across all patients being treated + total festering days recorded on their wound tracks.** Include every wound being treated; treating more people increases the combined difficulty.
- Count each track's current step from unwounded: Injured is 1, Severe injury is 2, and so on. Each recorded day of festering adds another **+1 DC** for that track.
- **Example:** One patient has an arm at Severe injury (2) with 2 festering days; another has a Cut/bruised torso (1) with no festering. Treating both costs 2 medical supplies and requires **DC 17** (12 + 2 + 1 + 2).
- **Success:** After a night of rest, reduce each injured wound track of every treated patient by one level and prevent that night's festering loss.
- **Failure:** The medical supplies are consumed, no wounds recover, and eligible wounds fester normally that night. Failed medical attention provides no protection. The caregiver may push the roll using the normal Push Your Luck rules.
- **Wound-caused unconsciousness:** The character can wake once the Head is below 4 wounds, the Core is below 6 wounds, and stamina is above -5. Healing one cause does not remove another.

This treatment supports overnight recovery; use **Stop Bleeding** above for immediate first aid.

Untreated Wounds

Wounds at **level 2 or higher** that receive no successful medical care fester. At the end of each night, lose **1 maximum stamina per qualifying wound track** and record **1 additional festering day on each such track**. Count each qualifying track once, not once per accumulated wound level. This includes the torso's second step, Injury (+1 DC).

Each festering day increases that wound's future healing DC contribution by **+1**. Successful medical care prevents another festering day that night; a failed attempt does not. A track below level 2 stops accumulating festering days, but retains its existing festering penalty until fully healed.

Example: An untreated Severe injury to an arm (level 2) and Disabled legs (level 3) reduce maximum stamina by **2 that night**. A typical human's maximum falls from 3 to 1. If both tracks remain untreated the following night, maximum stamina falls by another 2.

Track lost maximum stamina against the wound track that caused it. When that track **fully recovers to unwounded**, restore all maximum stamina lost to its festering and clear its festering days. Partial healing does not yet restore that maximum. Restoring maximum stamina restores capacity; recovery of current stamina is handled separately.

TODO — Festering: Any lower limit on maximum stamina, interaction with current stamina and unconsciousness, and whether magical treatment prevents a night's festering before full recovery.

TODO — Injury: Weapon-specific damage modifiers, action stamina costs, stamina recovery, exhaustion effects before unconsciousness, disabled-head effects, combined injury penalties and bleeding sources. Armor rules appear under Equipment.

TODO — Supplies: Bow/sling ammo and light consumption, medical supply effects, gear integrity/breakage thresholds; include only what the scenario uses. Crossbow/firearm ammo consumption appears under Weapon properties. Container and carrying rules appear under Equipment.

TODO — Horror: Environmental hazards, escape and full-rest conditions.

5. Magic

Certain spells and rituals can knit flesh, reattach limbs (even somebody else's), or potentially revive the dead. See the ritual descriptions for more information.

Knit-Flesh

Through extraordinary concentration, the caster stitches living or dead flesh together. Choose how many wounds **W** to heal from one body location before casting. On a successful Magic check, reduce that location's wound track by W levels. If a limb has been severed in the fiction, it can be reattached, even if it belongs to somebody else, leaving the location at Disabled. The process is unholy and excruciatingly painful, causing **1 Fear** to a living recipient. Repairing dead tissue does not itself revive the dead. See Knit-Flesh.

- **Magic DC:** 12 + 2 × W
- **Stamina cost:** 3 × W
- **Backlash on failure:** Copy the W wounds you attempted to heal onto the matching body location on yourself.

Reanimation

An intricate ritual that revives the dead on a successful Magic check, provided the body is a usable vessel. The revived character automatically gains a permanent madness (Bane) associated with their cause of death; see madness and Banes. A malevolent spirit always returns with them and co-occupies their body, creating a consequence that must be dealt with through the story. See Reanimation.

- **Magic DC:** Same scene DC 15, same day DC 17, same week DC 19, same year DC 21.
- **Stamina cost:** 10
- **Backlash on failure:** The malecolent spirit takes full control of the charater, with the original soul helpless to do anything.

Gout of Fire

Choose damage **D** before casting. The target takes D wounds regardless of the Magic check.

- **Magic DC:** 13 + D
- **Stamina cost:** 2 + D
- **Backlash on failure:** D wounds to the casting arm.

Spillover (target and caster): Start at a random body location for the target and the casting arm for backlash. Apply wounds until that location's track is full, then roll another location for remaining wounds. Stop when damage runs out or a previously rolled location repeats; discard any remaining wounds. The casting arm counts as already rolled.

6. The Test Session — Guide Only

Fear pacing: Alternate scares with opportunities to rest and recover. Usually allow recovery after one scare; two consecutive scares are occasional, three are rare, and four are reserved for characters pushing onward without rest. Offer the following-round recovery opportunity after Fear gains, subject to available anchors and Fear restrictions. Brief recovery removes only 1 Fear per scene; full rest resets it to 0.

TODO — Setup: Premise, objective, starting resources, player boundaries/pause procedure, session length.

TODO — Scenario: Exploration obstacle, dangerous encounter, escape decision; locations, clues, threat stats, DCs, supplies, escalation triggers, ending conditions. Allow avoidance and retreat.

Record: Pushes offered/accepted, chosen costs, outcomes, resources spent, medical supplies spent, failed treatment rolls, nights until recovery, confusing rules, Guide rulings, slow moments.

Feedback: When did you feel desperate? Was pushing a real choice? Did preparation matter? Did anchor commitment change your decisions? What slowed play?